

THE BIG HACK

A Kiwicon talk, staged as a play

Script export 2026-09-14

Branch stage/player · commit cb228c4 · revision shared-eab84de4241248af

17 scenes · 870 cues

CAST

Kristina	AI video
Liam	Live
Brendan	Live
Marcus	Live
Dana · People Partner	AI video
Officer One	AI video
Officer Two	AI video
Prosecutor	AI video
Judge	AI video
Defence Counsel	AI video

Liam, Brendan, Marcus are performed live on stage. Everyone else is a pre-rendered AI-video character, marked ► in the script; live and video characters never share a plane. Narrator lines are recorded voice-over. Italic lines are stage and screen directions.

PROLOGUE

1. Opening montage

Opening news montage. Play through Sam's pause and the Mountain Man introduction; GO begins the standup.

MOVEMENT I

2. Cold Open — The Standup

Morning. Liam sits at a dual-monitor desk in a bathrobe, barely out of bed: one monitor is a wall of Reddit anti-AI memes he scrolls with the mouse, the other holds the Zoom standup grid of coworker tiles.

A Reddit feed, r/programminghumor, scrolling. A meme fills it: "THIS HERE IS CALLED AI. YOU ASK IT QUESTIONS, AND IT CONFIDENTLY LIES TO YOU.". He chuckles and scrolls, another, then another, each a dunk on AI slop, and he keeps chuckling. He's clearly been at this a while. LIAM, bathrobe, hair flat from the pillow, slumped at the desk, one hand on the mouse. This is what he was doing before work, and it's what he's still doing. On the second monitor, off to the side, a Zoom standup grid of coworker tiles starts up; his own tile is a black square: his camera is off.

► **KRISTINA:** *(runs ~12s, Liam plays against it, Bright, brisk, a standup she has run a thousand times.)* Morning, everyone, I'd like to remind you all of the time limits on updates we agreed to last time so we can get through standup more effeciently. Liam, you're on mute, I think? And... your camera is off?

LIAM: *(live, not looking up, still scrolling)* Yeah sorry, I'm eating, so my camera's off today.

NARRATOR: He's very obviously not eating.

► **KRISTINA:** *(Warm, and she means it.)* No worries. Okay, I wanted to give some praise. The API developer portal we shipped this week, the feedback's been incredible. Two of our biggest integration partners shipped on it over the weekend. Support's quiet, adoption's climbing. Best launch we've had in ages.

► **KRISTINA:** *(turning to one tile in particular)* And that's so much down to Brendan who, I happen to know, put most of his weekend into getting it over the line. So. Thank you, genuinely. It did not go unnoticed.

BRENDAN: *(live, a modest glow, ducking it)* Oh thanks, that's... yeah. It kind of came together. I'm really happy with how it landed.

NARRATOR: Liam's heart skips a beat when he hears Brendan worked on the weekend...

LIAM: *(live, flat, to no one)* ...He shipped this feature on the weekend?

He clicks off the memes and drags the merged PR up, and starts sharing his screen uninvited.

► **KRISTINA:** Liam, you don't need to take over the screenshare...

LIAM: *(live, the first real attention he's paid all morning)* Hang on. This shipped? This is the developer portal... live? In front of partners, right now? Eight hundred lines in one PR. Who reviewed this?

BRENDAN: *(live, still gamely)* I mean it's been live since last Thursday, totally stable, partners are already on it, so...

LIAM: *(live)* Who reviewed all this code?

BRENDAN: *(live, a beat, honest)* ...Well I skimmed it. But I made sure there's a really robust set of tests and I eval'ed the functionality. The whole suite's green...

LIAM: *(live, pouncing)* You skimmed it..? What are you talking about, didn't you write this code? You vibecoded this, didn't you?

BRENDAN: *(live, reaching)* I used Claude Code, Opus 4.5 but I went back and forth with it, and the tests all pass, the partners haven't hit a single...

► **KRISTINA:** ... Liam can we take this offline so we can get through standup?

LIAM: *(live, riding his own certainty — the meme energy, out loud now)* The tests pass...? The AI wrote the code and the AI wrote the tests that say the code's fine. It doesn't understand any of it, it's just a next word predictor.

MARCUS: *(a tile unmutes; he has been waiting months for somebody to say this)* Yeah, well, what I keep saying... Nobody wants to talk about it... the AI is coming for our jobs.

LIAM: *(live, not looking up)* That's not what I said at all... I said the code is bad... what?

MARCUS: If you listened to what I said about the Luddites last week, Liam... the 1700's textile workers the British literally executed because the automated machines took their jobs... When they protested they got KILLED. The quality of the textiles actually got WORSE, but it didn't matter because it got cheaper. I wish you all would pay more attention to what's happening

NARRATOR: *(V.O.)* Marcus doesn't have this quite right, he's making some crude and quick assumptions to win an argument. It's thought that the quality of the garments actually went up via industrialization, not down. In the early days it was questionable, but in time there was no doubt, quality went up.

LIAM:

(live) Marcus, this has nothing to do with making clothes. We are hired to write good code and vibe coding writes garbage code. Can you please keep your politics out of this for 5 minutes? Kristina is trying to run standup.

► **KRISTINA:** Thanks Liam. Let's -

MARCUS: *(sincerely; he means it as a compliment)* But you're wrong, Liam. This has happened throughout history, with skilled workers being replaced by technology. Our boss will always try to replace us with technology if we don't -

LIAM: Marcus, you've already done your big speech on the Luddites last week. Do you mind if we talk about actual technology this time around, despite your hatred for it?

MARCUS: *(stopping dead; this one actually gets*

him) Well Kristina cut me off last week. I just don't want you to all blow me off, this is serious, we need to learn lessons from the past or we're doomed to repeat it, and the lesson the Luddites have to tell us...

► **KRISTINA:** Marcus, thank you for your input... but can we get through standup and then I promise I'll give you an opportunity to share your concerns

He has lost LIAM completely. Something on the diff has him.

LIAM: *(live)* ...Wait. Hold on. Are these, are these long-lived API tokens?

BRENDAN: *(live, careful)* ...Yeah. The keys are long-lived.

LIAM: *(live, genuinely affronted, the real engineer surfacing)* Did nobody read my memo? I wrote an entire memo on this. We should only be using JWTs. They're stateless, you verify the signature, you're not hitting the database on every single request. They expire on their own. It's all in there, with diagrams. But no. Of course. Of course the AI didn't read my memo.

BRENDAN: *(live, quiet — then, honest)* ...Actually, it did. I fed your memo into Claude before I started. It read the whole thing and the first version did have JWT's. I can pull up the first commit, it's exactly what you recommended in your memo

► **KRISTINA:** *(stepping in — to take the heat off Brendan, and to be straight)* and then I'm the one who had him remove the JWT's. That part's on me, Liam. Not Brendan, and not the AI. The switch to long-lived keys was my call.

LIAM: *(live, rounding on her instead)* ...Why on earth would you do that.

► **KRISTINA:** *(even; she has the receipts)* Because we user-tested it. The JWT flow, the refresh, the expiry, it confused every integration partner we put it in front of; half of them dropped off right at token refresh. The expirations tanked adoption. Long-lived keys, are just easier to understand. And yes, I know what a leaked key does. It's live until somebody rotates it. It's a tradeoff, and I made the call.

LIAM: *(live, patient, awful — explaining gravity to a child)* That's not a product call. That's a cyber security decision, and you made it in a user study. If you had a software engineering degree, Kristina, you'd understand why that was never yours to override.

NARRATOR: Kristina holds her tongue, she is in disbelief about what Liam just said.

...

Just dead air

MARCUS: *(level, unhurried, taking his time about it)* Liam, you just asked a woman on this call whether she's qualified to have an opinion. In front of everyone.

LIAM: *(live, honestly puzzled)* I'd have asked you the same thing.

MARCUS: That isn't the point. The point is who tends to get asked.

And KRISTINA comes back. Not to deal with Liam. To deal with the man defending her.

► **KRISTINA:** *(bright, quick)* It's fine. Thank you, Marcus. Let's keep moving, we're over time already.

MARCUS: *(finishing it anyway)* I'd just like it noted that somebody said something.

She lets that sit for a second... Marcus spoke out to give himself credit..

► **KRISTINA:** *(brisk, moving us along)* Right. Liam, anyway, what are you on this week, and is anything blocking you?

LIAM: *(live, back to scrolling, bored)* Still chasing the race condition in the signup flow. No blockers.

► **KRISTINA:** Great. What's your estimate to completion? Just a rough number.

LIAM: *(live, flat)* It's a race condition. Could be a one-line fix, could be a rewrite of the whole session handler. I'm not going to invent a number so a spreadsheet feels better.

► **KRISTINA:** *(not taking the bait, typing)* ...Sure. I'll put two weeks. Thanks, everyone, that's standup.

Liam goes back to looking at the reddit memes.

3. The Cursor Demo

Continuous with the cold open — the standup grid has emptied to just two tiles, Kristina and Brendan, in a quiet post-standup huddle; Liam is gone. The screens stay with them: two coworker tiles, and then a shared screen as Brendan walks Kristina through Cursor live — plan mode, a plan that looks confident but is...

The slack huddle sound starts playing... Kristina is calling Brandon

► **KRISTINA:** *(quiet, just to Brendan now)* ...Hey. Liam's comment about my Degree. I've been sitting here half-deciding whether it's an HR conversation.

BRENDAN: *(live, caught between them, careful)* ...Honestly? It wasn't okay. But he's not a bad guy. He's thorny. He's also the best engineer I've worked with, I've learned more from him than from anyone here. You just learn to work around the edges of him.

► **KRISTINA:** "Work around him." That's the job, is it.

BRENDAN: *(live, a small, honest shrug)* ...Kind of? Sometimes. I don't think HR fixes him. I think it just makes the next standup worse for both of you.

She sits with it. Lets it go for now.

► **KRISTINA:** *(changing the subject — and something underneath it)* ...Okay. I actually wanted to talk to you about something else.. vibe coding... It seems like recently when Opus 4.5 dropped something changed, and I haven't had a chance to tinker with any of it. Can you show me your setup?

BRENDAN: *(live, lighting up)* Yeah happily. Fair warning, it's rougher than you might think. But it's honestly the most fun I've had in years. Let's build something real together. You know that ChatOps bot you keep saying we need, close a Jira ticket from Slack? Nobody's had time. Let's just... try it. Right now.

► **KRISTINA:** *(skeptical, game)* I mean I've watched half of Twitter vibe-code a startup over a weekend.... your right, this is fun

BRENDAN:

(live) Perfect. Open Cursor. Top right, put it in plan mode. Then just tell it what you want, like you'd brief a contractor. Your own words.

► **KRISTINA:** *(reading as she types)* Okay... "Build a Slack bot so our team can close Jira tickets from a slash command, slash-jira-done, and post back a clean confirmation."

BRENDAN: *(live, grinning)* Yep. Send it.

She hits enter. A plan streams out on screen, steps, files, an architecture. It looks authoritative. At the foot of it, a prompt waits "Proceed?"

BRENDAN: *(live, scanning it — the practiced eye, slowing her down)* Okay see, this is the part people skip. It looks confident, but it's guessing. This is actually exactly what Liam was talking about. Look, it invented a Jira endpoint. "Tickets-slash-close." That's not a real call; that doesn't exist. And down here, it wants to paste the API token straight into the code.

► **KRISTINA:** *(deadpan, the penny dropping)* ...hardcode the credentials. So Liam wasn't just being dramatic this morning....

BRENDAN: *(live, a small laugh)* No, he's not usually wrong ... but what he left off is how much faster it is to correct it when it's wrong, than it is to do it yourself. Try telling it that it's wrong...

► **KRISTINA:** *(typing, getting it)* "Research the real Jira REST API, verify the endpoints actually exist and keep the token in Vault, nothing hardcoded." See, I do listen on the security stuff.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Exactly. And make it check its own work; have it write tests and run them against the sandbox before it touches anything real. Okay... run it.

They run it. very quickly hundreds of lines of code get generated

BRENDAN: *(live, nodding at the green)* There, its own tests pass. Now it wants to install to your Slack.

A dialog box on screen the Slack app and Jira integration are built. "Install the Slack app to your workspace now?" buttons: Approve / Deny.

► **KRISTINA:** ...It's asking me. I just approve it without reading the code?

BRENDAN: *(live)* Yup..

She clicks. A green check.

BRENDAN: *(live)* There, it's live in your Slack now. Try it out

► **KRISTINA:** Right. Give me one of yours, what have you got open?

BRENDAN: *(live)* Oh sorry, I haven't got any in there. I've been tracking my stuff in Linear since the launch

► **KRISTINA:** ...Linear...?

BRENDAN: *(live)* Yeah I find it a little easier to use than Jira, I'm sorry if that messes our workflows up

► **KRISTINA:** *(waving it off, entirely warm)* Work however makes you most productive, that's the whole point of any of this... Just give me access to your linear and I'll copy it over into Jira

BRENDAN:

(live) Are you sure that's alright? Because I'm still fairly new, and if there's a process thing I'm supposed to follow...

► **KRISTINA:** Brendan. Honestly. Send me the board and I'll cross post it into Jira, I'll figure it out my end. Do the work in whatever gets you moving fastest. That's what matters, and that's what gets you noticed.

BRENDAN: *(live)* ...Okay. Thanks.

► **KRISTINA:** *(typing into Slack, narrating)* Anyway I'll use one of mine for the test, then. Okay... slash, jira, done, P-R-O-J four-twelve...

She hits enter. Slack pings back: "PROJ-412 Closed." Behind it, on the board, the card slides over to Done.

under the green confirmation, in small grey text neither of them reads: "...and 3 linked issues resolved." The board quietly shuffles three more cards to Done.

► **KRISTINA:** *(a stunned beat, then genuinely — but measured)* ...it actually closed it. Okay. Yeah, I get why you said this is fun

► **KRISTINA:** *(the thing that's been sitting there since standup)* The thing Liam said about the code, though. That it writes its own tests, so of course they pass. Marking its own homework. He's not wrong about it, is he?

BRENDAN: *(live, lighting up — this is the thing he's been dying to explain)* I'm actually really happy to hear you ask that. Let me show you my process.

► **KRISTINA:** Please. Yes. Show me.

BRENDAN shares his screen, a plan-mode plan.

BRENDAN: *(live)* So the thing liam mention this morning: you read eight hundred lines of AI code top to bottom. Nobody can do that, you'd go blind by line two hundred, that's actually true regardless of who wrote it. So for years human written code was split into smaller patches that are easier to review. But imagine you joined a new company and needed to learn how a service worked. You wouldn't read all the code, you would start with the documentation. So when it comes to AI code, you don't start with the code at all. You start here, this is the plan it wrote before it touched a single file. It's the documentation, the architecture, the tradeoffs, where the secrets go. That's two pages, and that's where the real decisions live. I read that like a hawk.

► **KRISTINA:** *(leaning in)* ...Oh. I didn't really think about it like that...

BRENDAN: *(live)* Then the dangerous parts, the auth, the token handling, anything that can actually hurt someone, I read every line myself. That's maybe five percent of what it writes. The boring ninety-five percent, I skim at best, and just focus on robust functional testing.

► **KRISTINA:** But that's his whole point, the AI writes the tests...

BRENDAN: *(live, scrolling to the testing section of the plan)* The tests that actually matter, the integration tests, I write those into the plan, and review those carefully. Real partner sandbox, real tokens. And then it has access to any errors it generates, and part of the plan involves how to resolve and handle errors.

► **KRISTINA:** *(quiet awe)* ...So even though it wrote the tests, you architected them?

BRENDAN: *(live)* Yeah it's probably the most important part, telling it how to evaluate its work.

► **KRISTINA:** *(the refrain, and she means*

it) Brendan, this is the future. Do you get that? This is the entire future of how we build things. Everyone still doing it the old way is about to look like they're carving stone tablets.

► **KRISTINA:** *(bright — the obvious thought)* Did you show Liam this? Because if he's genuinely worried about the tests, this is the answer to his entire objection. He'd love it.

BRENDAN: *(live, a beat — the air*

changes) ...I tried. I, uh, I couldn't really get it in front of him. I think I just need to spend a bit more time with him. One on one. To get him to actually sit with it.

A pause. Kristina's tile stills.

► **KRISTINA:** *(slower)* ...Oh. You "tried." So you struggle with communicating with him too? And you're the one person here he actually likes.

BRENDAN: *(live, not wanting to bury him)* ...He'll come around. He's the smartest person on the team, Kristina, genuinely. He'll be incredible at this when he finally warms up to it.

► **KRISTINA:** *(half to herself, the manager surfacing)* ...Right. "Will be." ...He's a bit of a challenge, though. Isn't he. Not a bad person. Just a challenge.

She sits with it for a half-second

► **KRISTINA:** *(brightening again)* ...Anyway. God, though, look at this slack bot, ten minutes of work. Imagine the whole team moving like this. Imagine what next quarter looks like. I haven't been this excited about this job in years. Go, do your actual work. And Brendan? Thank you..

Her tile blinks out, still glowing. BRENDAN sits alone.

4. The PR Review

Continuous — Brendan takes Liam's Slack huddle. Liam is live at the same dual-monitor desk, still in the bathrobe, the memes finally gone: he's dragged the merged portal diff back up onto the big monitor and he's been stewing.

The standup has just cleared. The slack huddle sound plays... Liam is calling brandon...

LIAM: *(live, gruff — not his comfort zone, getting it out of the way first)* Before you say anything. The Kristina thing this morning, what I said about her degree. That landed like shit. I know. I shouldn't have said it like that.

BRENDAN: *(live, caught off guard he's saying it)* ...Okay. Yeah. It really did.

LIAM:

(live) But I wasn't wrong to be worried. I'm not trying to bully her, I think we're about to get burned and nobody in that room is listening, and it comes out of my mouth as... ..that. I'm bad at this. I know I'm bad at this.

BRENDAN: *(live, gently)* ...Honestly? If you said it to her the way you just said it to me, it'd go a lot better.

LIAM: *(live, already moving on — can't stay in it)* Yeah, well. Anyway. That's not why I called. The weekend.... Since when do we work weekends?

BRENDAN: *(live, level)* It wasn't a weekend, Liam. It was maybe three hours Saturday because I was bored and messing around with the new Opus. Most of it happened while I was making coffee

LIAM: *(live, the real reason, leaning in)* But the code. Show me. Walk me through what you actually did, the whole thing, start to finish. I want to see how you wrote this.

BRENDAN: *(live, easy, glad to — sharing his screen)* Yeah, course. So, honestly the way I work now, I start with the cursor plan. If you look at...

On the big monitor BRENDAN pulls something up, his cursor plan from Saturday. LIAM does not look at it. He has grabbed the diff back and is already scrolling.

LIAM: *(live, over him, jabbing at the screen)* Eight hundred lines. One PR. The front-end, the key-issuance service, the auth, the deploy config, all jammed into one diff. How is anybody supposed to review this?

Private ChatGPT lookup. Let the question and answer finish, then GO.

BRENDAN: *(live)* That's... okay, that's actually kind of my point, you don't review it by reading...

LIAM: *(live, cutting in)* You don't review it at all, is the answer. You can't. Nobody read this. I could not, in good conscience, put my name on this, and I've been doing this twenty years. Here. Line four hundred. This function. What does it do? Off the top of your head what does it do and why is it shaped like this?

BRENDAN: *(live, patient)* I... I can tell you, but that's not really how I check it now, if you'd let me show you the process I follow...

LIAM: *(live, not hearing it — this is the thing he knows)* Because that's what review is. You read it. Line by line. You hold the entire thing in your head at once. That's the job. That's the whole thing that separates an engineer from someone typing paragraphs at a chatbot and hitting accept.

BRENDAN: *(live, one real attempt — pulling the transcript up again)* Liam, genuinely, give me two minutes. Let me actually show you how I reviewed it. There's the plan, there's the whole session, the tests I wrote, the way I...

LIAM: *(live, waving at the screen without looking)* I don't need the guided tour of Cursor, Brendan. I can read code. I was reading code before Cursor existed. And don't tell me the tests pass. The AI wrote the code and wrote the tests that say the code's fine. It's marking its own homework. I made this exact point three hours ago.

BRENDAN: *(live, quietly, the fourth time he's started a sentence he won't finish)* ...I wrote the evals myself actually, against our staging env...

LIAM: *(live, over him again, certain)* You've all decided the thing is smart because it's confident. It is not smart. It's a very fast intern who has never once in its life said "I don't know." And you're letting it near production.

BRENDAN just... stops. He's realised he isn't going to get in. LIAM reads the silence as agreement.

LIAM: *(live, softening — and this is the worst part, because he means it)* Look. I'm not doing this to be a dick. I'm trying to help you. You're good, Brendan, you're actually good, that's why I bother. Most of these people I wouldn't waste the breath on. I don't want to watch you turn into someone who can't work without the thing holding his hand.

BRENDAN: *(live, a long beat — he lets the whole thing go)* ...Yeah. Okay, Liam. I hear you.

LIAM: *(live, satisfied, having registered none of it)* Good. Split it into smaller PRs next time. And read your diffs, all of them, not the machine's summary. You'll thank me for this in five years.

BRENDAN: *(live, flat, done trying — reaching for the door)* ...Sure. Thanks. I've gotta get back to it.

BRENDAN drops the huddle, the plan and transcript still open on the screen, unread. LIAM is alone at the desk with the diff. He scrolls it a while longer, hunting for the flaw that would prove him right. He doesn't find one. He doesn't look satisfied either.

MOVEMENT II

5. Good Instinct

The same desk as the cold open, the next morning — but no memes today. Liam is actually working: deep in the session-handler code on the big monitor, headphones half-on, a scatter of coffee cups.

NARRATOR: A few months pass... Anthropic has just released Opus 4.7. Liam is working at his desk, caught up in the signup race condition. On his second monitor, the morning standup is already running.

► **KRISTINA:** *(brisk, running the board)* ...lovely, thanks Brendon. Marcus, anything blocking you?

MARCUS: Nothing blocking. Three tickets, all merged... by Claude.

► **KRISTINA:** *(taking it as a joke, moving on)* Ha. Great. Liam...

MARCUS: Sorry, can I say one thing that isn't a ticket? It's quick.

► **KRISTINA:** *(the pause of a woman who has been here before)* Is it quick? Remember we agreed to time limits Marcus...

MARCUS: It's quick. It's true that shipping features faster than we ever have, but we're also just getting turned into sweat shop workers hitting approve on Claude.

► **KRISTINA:** Marcus, we agreed on not bringing this up during standup...

MARCUS: *(going anyway, and this is the first real history in the play)* No Kristina, because this has all happened before. In the 1700's there were power looms driven by steam that were unsafe to operate but could make textiles way faster than the workers of the time, who used to work from home and were well compensated...

LIAM: *(live, headphones half on, eyes still on the code)* Maybe you shouldn't get your lessons from the losing side of history.

MARCUS: ...What?

LIAM: *(live)* They complained just because technology which was clearly better for society had an impact on their jobs, then they burned factories to the ground... They got hanged by the British army. Seems pretty clear cut they were on the wrong side of history... Anyway, I'm trying to read this code. Please stop talking about the Luddites.

MARCUS: *(not done)* Liam, never mind how horrible that is to talk about people that died like that, this is far from the only time workers suffered at the hands of new technology. Do you know the story of John Henry, racing against the machine building railroad tracks?

► **KRISTINA:** *(trying)* Marcus...

MARCUS: *(going anyway)* John Henry raced against the machines to prove he could drive rail spikes faster than the steam-powered rail spike machine, and he actually won. He drove more, and what did he get for it? A heart attack. Liam, you're going to give yourself a heart attack.

Private ChatGPT lookup. Let the question and answer finish, then GO.

► **KRISTINA:** (*pleasant, immovable, moving the board on*) Okay. Marcus, you got your word in, thanks. Liam. You're still on the signup race condition, yeah? Where are we with that one?

LIAM: (*live, not looking up, still reading code*) Still on it. No blockers.

► **KRISTINA:** (*Gentle, but she needs something.*) Right, that's what you said yesterday, though. It's been open a while now. Is there any movement? Any updates I can add to the ticket?

LIAM: (*live, the flat patience of a man explaining the obvious*) It's a race condition, Kristina. I don't debug in a straight line. You don't "make progress" on one of these, you stare at it until you figure it out, and then it's done. It's not a burndown chart. I'm still staring.

Private ChatGPT lookup. Let the question and answer finish, then GO.

► **KRISTINA:** (*not rising to it, typing*) ...Okay. I'm trying to make the tradeoff visible. We've had four reports in three months; behind it we've got tickets affecting hundreds of users. I need some sense of whether this is another day or another week.

LIAM: (*live, finally looking up — sharp, but right*) Four people got dropped into somebody else's account. That's not a support-volume question. That's a security issue. If it happens once, it's a security incident; if it happens four times, we stop counting tickets and fix it.

Private ChatGPT lookup. Let the question and answer finish, then GO.

► **KRISTINA:** (*takes the correction; no defensiveness*) Fair. You're right.

BRENDAN: (*live, easy, genuine — a hand up, not a challenge*) I could jump on it with you if you want? I've had my head in the auth stuff all week anyway, happy to be a second pair of eyes.

LIAM: (*live, a soft, kind-sounding condescension*) ...That's good of you. It's a concurrency bug, though, down in the session handler. No offence. It's just... this is the kind of thing that takes a while to even see.

He hears himself say what he said outloud, and thinks back to yesterday...

LIAM: (*live, softening, almost warm*) ...Actually. No. Come look at it with me. You'll learn more from one real race condition than a month of tickets. Free for twenty minutes after this?

BRENDAN: (*live, lighting up*) Yeah for sure. I'd love that, honestly. I'll ping you the second we're done.

► **KRISTINA:** (*pleased — a manager watching a good thing happen*) Oh, I love that. Pair on it. Right, that's the board. Thanks, everyone.

The grid blinks out tile by tile. A Slack huddle request lights Liam's screen: BRENDAN. He takes it without looking up.

LIAM: (*live, in his element now — the version of him people like*) Okay. So. Four users in three months. Each one signs up, and for about a second they're... in someone else's account. Someone else's name, someone else's email, right there on the screen. Then it clears. And I cannot reproduce it. I have tried everything. Ten thousand signups in a loop, locally, nothing. It only ever happens out there. In prod. Under real traffic.

BRENDAN: *(live, leaning in, genuinely into it)* Okay, that's kind of horrifying. Where've you been looking?

LIAM: *(live)* Token generation. The session tokens. If two people ever got issued the same token, that would do it, so I've been pulling apart the RNG, the entropy source, the signing. And it's all fine. It's textbook. That's what's killing me the one place it should be, it just... isn't.

Private ChatGPT lookup. Let the question and answer finish, then GO.

BRENDAN: *(live, careful, offering)* Can I ask a dumb thing? Have you tried pointing Claude at the repo and asking it to investigate the signup flow?

NARRATOR: Brendan asks Claude Code to investigate the bug. Quickly it gets to work without Liam the wiser.

LIAM: *(live, a short laugh — not cruel, just certain)* It can't. That's the thing everyone gets wrong about it. It can't reason about concurrency, it's autocomplete with good manners. It has no model of two threads interleaving. You point it at this, it sees the word "session," it pattern-matches to "add a mutex," and now I've got a lock on the hottest path in the app and a deadlock in prod. No thanks.

Private ChatGPT lookup. Let the question and answer finish, then GO.

BRENDAN: *(live, nodding, tries another door)* Fair. What if you gave it reproduction steps first though so it has something to eval against?

LIAM: *(live)* That's the whole problem, though. I can't make it fail on demand. It's one in fifty thousand signups, only under real load. There's no red test to hand it. And if I hand it a green one, it'll "fix" the bug, tell me it's solved, and be lying, same as it always is. And it'll sound completely sure while it does it.

NARRATOR: Claude finished working a little while ago. It proved the root cause was in the `getOrCreateSession` call, and it has a script that can reliably reproduce the bug. Beneath it, it has a one-line fix for the problem.

BRENDAN: *(live, one more, tentative)* Okay one last idea with claude, then I'll shut up. The incident thread's got the actual prod logs from when it happened. What if I dropped those in claude, the real ones and see if there's

LIAM: *(live, sharp — the one objection that's flat-out right)* No! You do not paste production session data into a third-party model. Those logs have live tokens in them. Real users' emails. That's a PII incident and a security review all by itself, that's exactly the "just paste it in and see what happens" thinking that gets a company on the news. ...come on Brendan, you know better...

BRENDAN: *(live, quietly — and he means it)* No, you're right. You are. Forget that one.

BRENDAN: *(live, offhand, like it just floated up — the dumb-question voice)* ...Okay, this is probably nothing. But can you scroll up? To where signup actually calls the session thing. That `getOrCreateSession`, what's it keyed on?

LIAM: *(live, scrolling up, humouring him)* The user id. It keys the session on the user id.

BRENDAN: *(live, carefully — leaving the door open, not walking through it)* Right, but that call's before the commit, isn't it? The database row hasn't actually landed yet. So for that one moment... what's the id? Is it the real one yet?

LIAM stops. Actually stops. His eyes go to the top of the function, then down, then back up tracing it. The cursor hovers. When he speaks it's quiet, almost to himself.

LIAM: *(live, slow)* ...It's zero. The id is zero until the transaction commits. It defaults to zero. So two signups in the same tick they both call `getOrCreateSession` with id zero. They both key on zero. They get the same session. One of them gets handed the other one's login. ...It was never the tokens. It was never the crypto. It's a check-then-set on an id that isn't there yet. One line. It's one line. It's been one line this whole time.

He turns genuinely lit up, the most alive he has been, and looks into the webcam at BRENDAN.

LIAM: *(live, warm — no condescension left in it)* ...That's a hell of a catch, Brendan. How did you even.... that's the one place I wasn't looking. That's real instinct. Good instinct, kid. Seriously.

BRENDAN: *(live, a modest deflection — and something underneath he can't name)* ...I dunno. It just looked a bit off to me. Lucky guess.

NARRATOR: LIAM is already dropping back into the code, buzzing, typing the one-line fix happy, restored, the craft-love back in his hands. He doesn't look at the other screen. He wouldn't think to. On BRENDAN's laptop Claude's proof glows a second longer: REPRODUCED, the two screenshots, the script, the completed one-line-fix branch and the shared-store warning. Then BRENDAN quietly checks out the main branch. He leaves the fix branch dangling on his computer. He does not show Liam. He lets the huddle go. LIAM types on, warm and none the wiser. Hold a moment on the two screens, his, bright and moving, and on brandon's just a blinking cursor from a rolled back commit.

6. Heads Together

A quick Slack call about twenty minutes later. Brendan is live at his desk; Kristina answers from her tile on the shared screen, so the scene is cued live against a clip.

Later that afternoon we find Kristina and Brendan on yet another Slack huddle

BRENDAN: *(live, easy, pleased)* Oh one more thing before you drop, that signup race condition? It's done. Liam and I got it this morning.

► **KRISTINA:** *(lighting up — genuinely glad)* Stop it. The one he wouldn't put a number on? Brendan, that's brilliant. See, this is exactly what I keep saying. You get the right two people in a huddle, you put your heads together, and the thing that's been stuck for weeks just... falls out. Great work!

BRENDAN: *(live, a beat — he can't quite take that)* ...Yeah. I mean... honestly, though? It wasn't really heads-together. I pointed Claude at the signup flow and.... It found the race, reproduced it locally, wrote a script for it, it even gave me screenshots of one test user inside the other's account. Then it made the fix on a branch. I basically just read the diagnosis back to him.

A small pause.

► **KRISTINA:** *(slower now)* ...Wait. Hold on. So Liam.... He's been on this how long? It's been sitting on the board for weeks.

BRENDAN: *(live, seeing where it's heading)* ...A while, yeah.

► **KRISTINA:** Weeks. And you... this morning.... pointed Claude at the repo, and it found the bug, proved it and fixed it in one shot?

BRENDAN: *(live, quiet)* ...Kind of. Yeah.

KRISTINA sits back.

► **KRISTINA:** *(half to herself, a breath)* That's... that changes a lot, actually... it makes me think a little differently about Claude and Cursor...

BRENDAN: *(live, stepping in for him — quick, protective)* Okay, but, it's not like that, though. It found it fast, but the code was all laid out clean, the way Liam architected it. If the code quality and documentation wasn't as high as it was... and that's all him. ...He's the best engineer here, and he holds us all to a high standard of excellence

► **KRISTINA:** *(gently, not letting him off it)* Would Claude have found it without him on the call, though? If you were working the problem by yourself?

BRENDAN doesn't want to say it.

BRENDAN: *(live, reluctant)* ...Probably. Yeah. It worked pretty autonomously without much input. It didn't really need him.

Neither of them says the next bit out loud. KRISTINA lets it settle, then the bright manager clicks back into place, with something new

► **KRISTINA:** *(brisk again, warm)* Right. Well, however we got there, it's fixed, and that's genuinely great, and I get to tell my boss we have an extra engineer to work on new products this coming sprint.

BRENDAN: *(live, uneasy — one more, smaller)* ...Yeah. Just, do me a favor? Don't make it a thing. With Liam. He's genuinely the happiest I've seen him in ages. I don't want to take that away from him.

► **KRISTINA:** *(stops — confused)* ...Wait, what do you mean? You told him you used Claude, right?

BRENDAN: *(live, caught)* Well, no... He takes these things a little hard, you know? He put a lot of time into the bug and just got so excited when we found the issue together...

► **KRISTINA:** *(not angry; genuinely challenging him)* Brendan, how is Liam ever going to get better if you don't show him how to do this stuff?

They look at each other.

BRENDAN: *(live, conceding, careful)* You're not... wrong. I just have to ease him into some of it.

► **KRISTINA:** *(warm again — sincere)* Well, God bless you for that. I know how thorny he is. Nice work, Brendan. Really. A win is a win.

NARRATOR: Her tile blinks out. BRENDAN sits a second in the quiet. We now see LIAM leaning back from his desk, stretches, genuinely happy. He opens his one-line-fix branch for PR. On the screen above, BRENDAN deletes his local branch, the branch Claude finished twenty minutes ago. The monitor-blue holds on the two of them: the man proudly offering up the fix, and the one quietly erasing the proof that it was already done.

7. Best Practices

The same desk, a few weeks on from the reorg. The agent-first mandate is now just how the team works.

NARRATOR: A few months later. We find ourselves again in Liam's apartment, the memes are gone. On his desk sits a new Mac Mini, the protective film still on one corner. A terminal crawls a few tokens... at... a... time, running a local version of Qwen.

► **KRISTINA:** *(brisk, warm, moving down a fast board)* ...great, ship it. Okay, Liam. The billing-webhook retry ticket. That's been with you since Monday? Just checking it's not stuck.

LIAM: *(live, even, a man doing it right)* It's not stuck. I'm reviewing what AI wrote, line by line.

► **KRISTINA:** *(gentle)* Okay. It's just that Marcus had three tickets related to webhooks completed yesterday... Would it be helpful for you to pair with Marcus on this one?

LIAM:
(live) Marcus pastes our source into a stranger's computer and hits accept. I run mine locally AND I read what comes back. Which is what our own security policy requires, in case you all forgot to read it... So because they made these tools mandatory at the All Hands, local inference is the only setup that satisfies both policies... So I'm the only person on this call who's actually following the rules.

MARCUS: *(a tile unmutes; he heard his name)* I'm just doing what the CEO wants Liam. Don't you remember his memo? And rather than dragging my feet by using some crappy open source model, I got my work done. No wonder you think this technology sucks. You really are like the Luddites. They also complained about losing their craft, even though the power loom was the way of the future. You should try reading about it sometime.

LIAM: *(Sarcastically)* ...Okay Marcus... I'm pretty sure you were arguing the exact opposite about Luddites like a couple months ago.

MARCUS: And since we're pointing fingers. Do you know what those three tickets got me, Liam?

LIAM: *(live)* What?

MARCUS: Three more tickets. Because we have an endless supply of work. I feel like I'm the only one who understands what we're actually hired to do. They want us to use the fast model so we can produce more and more and more and never satisfy them.

LIAM: *(live, honestly puzzled anyone is saying this out loud)* What do you want, a slower model so you can work slower?

MARCUS: I want one person at this company to say out loud who the speed is actually for. Because it isn't me.

LIAM: *(live)* I don't have a view on that. I'm not a politician, I'm an engineer, and I have a threat model. You're pasting our source into somebody else's datacentre because it's quick. That's my objection. It's got nothing to do with how rich it makes the CEO.

A pause with a decision in it. He came here to talk about who the work is for. Nobody is going to have that conversation, so he starts one they will.

MARCUS: So you're going to waste time upsetting your boss and everyone else. You keep saying you read every line.

LIAM: *(live)* Because I do.

MARCUS: Well, I don't. I merged 3 PRs yesterday, and honestly, I think the AI does a better job at the review than I do. That's what the job is now. Hitting approve. Faster.

LIAM: *(live)* Right. Maybe AI does do a better job than YOU, and that's the difference between US.

MARCUS: Yeah, but you're not using the same technology as the rest of us. Instead, you're using some crappy CHINESE model on some overpriced machine that isn't even half as good and is probably backdooring our codebase...

LIAM: *(live)* Which is why I read every line before it merges.

MARCUS: A backdoor can be one character long. One equals sign where there should be two. You'd read straight past it. That's the whole reason it works.

That one lands. Nobody says so.

LIAM: *(live)* I've caught plenty of bugs by reading code this year.

MARCUS: Yeah, bugs, but not a CHINESE backdoor designed to be hard to detect.

And LIAM does not have the answer to that one, so he answers a different question, quickly, and well.

LIAM: *(live, conceding the premise like it costs him nothing)* Fine. Say the weights are poisoned. Say it's in there. What is it going to do? The box has no network. The model has no tools. It can't run a command, it can't open a socket, it can't touch a file I don't hand it. It types text into a window and I read the text.

► **KRISTINA:** *(trying, early)* Guys, can we get back on...

LIAM: *(live, not hearing her — the jab he's been saving)* You'd have to be an idiot to worry about poisoned weights and then hand the thing a shell and the internet. Which is what Claude does. It runs commands, it installs whatever it decides it needs, it browses the web, on every laptop in this building. Including yours.

► **KRISTINA:** *(trying again)* Guys, I want to get through the...

MARCUS: *(over her)* Sorry, Kristina, one more flag, because this actually matters. If anything off that Chinese model Liam is using lands in the product, and it comes out later the weights were compromised, that's on everyone on this call. I want it noted that I flagged it.

LIAM: *(live)* Noted where, Marcus? Nobody's taking minutes. It's a standup.

NARRATOR: *(V.O.)* Kristina takes the minutes every day during standup. She emails them out as part of a nicely styled report to the whole team every week.

► **KRISTINA:** *(a full sentence, at last; the patience is professional-grade)* Liam, Marcus, take the model debate to a thread. I'd honestly love a doc, it sounds like there's real stuff in there. Just not in our standup

MARCUS: *(frustrated)* I know what a standup is. I'm saying this matters more than the standup does.

► **KRISTINA:** Noted. Thanks. Let's move on.

MARCUS: *(over her, and hurt about*

it) With respect, I'm the one who said something when he made fun of your education...

► **KRISTINA:** *(flat; the only moment all morning the brightness isn't there)* Marcus I just want ONE STANDUP where we get through without...

LIAM: *(live, and it is almost generous)* At least we can all agree not to use Grok.

MARCUS: Oh, don't get me started -

► **KRISTINA:** *(calling it, warm and immovable)* Okay. Agreement! Finally... Any other blockers?

BRENDAN: *(live, tired around the eyes, still warm)* Liam, want me to hop on for twenty about the actual webhook thing? Just the webhook thing.

LIAM: *(live, a beat — then, almost warm)* ...Yeah. Alright. Come see the setup, actually. You'll like it.

The grid blinks out. A Slack huddle opens.

LIAM: *(live, showing off the good version of himself — the craftsman; he pats the silver cube once, like a fender)* Okay. So. Mac Studio, a 64 gigs of unified memory. The 27b Qwen just fits, quantized. Cost this company half the price of a used car which is the AI-adoption price the CEO's memo didn't mention.

Private ChatGPT lookup. Let the question and answer finish, then GO.

BRENDAN: *(live, genuinely taken with it, for a second)* And they approved that?

LIAM: *(live, a dry little shrug)* I wrote "AI" on the expense report. Approved within the hour, no questions. Which is silly. But it's the policy, and I'm inside it.

BRENDAN: *(live, honest, then careful)* It's a beautiful machine, honestly. What's it giving you in tokens a second?

LIAM: *(live, unbothered)* Two to five.

BRENDAN: *(live)* And time to first token? With the codebase in context.

A pause with a shape to it.

LIAM: *(live)* It varies.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Liam.

LIAM: *(live)* Six minutes. Sometimes eight. It's reading four hundred files, it's allowed to take longer than a search box. I batch my questions. You learn to think before you prompt, which would do some people on that call a world of good.

BRENDAN: *(live, no fight in it, just arithmetic)* Sure. It's just... six minutes in, five tokens a second out. On the webhook ticket. How much of your day is watching it type?

LIAM: *(live, and the honesty is the problem)* Less than you'd think. Some.

BRENDAN: *(live)* How many do you run at once? Agents.

LIAM: *(live — the question doesn't parse)* ...One. It's one model. What would I want two for?

BRENDAN: *(live)* They can talk to each other. If you let them.

LIAM: *(live, flat)* Talk to each other.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Share notes. Split the work up between them.

LIAM: *(live)* No.

NARRATOR: BRENDAN leaves it there. He ran five of them this morning, in parallel, before this call. He looks at Liam's one terminal, the cursor blinking, patient. He decides to sit on it.

NARRATOR: On BRENDAN's own screen he quietly types one line: "In billing/webhooks.rb, make failed deliveries retry with exponential backoff, cap at 5." The cloud agent opens the handler itself, writes the diff itself, runs the test itself. Green. Done before Liam finishes his sentence. He says nothing.

LIAM: *(live, warming up — this is the part he likes)* Watch the workflow, though. This is the part everyone skips. There. It invented a method that doesn't exist. And that's fine. Because I don't ask it to be right, I ask it to type the boring part. Then I do the job. It's autocomplete, Brendan. Fancy autocomplete. That's all any of this is under the hood.

BRENDAN: *(live, careful)* You could let it do more than stub, though. Let it run its own code install the dependencies, run the tests, see what fails....

LIAM: *(live)* No. Were you not listening at standup? You've seen the stories, rogue agents deleting production databases because somebody let them run whatever they wanted. I don't give it tool calls. It writes text. I decide what the text is worth running.

BRENDAN: *(live, one more try, gentle)* The hosted ones sandbox all of that now. The agent can only touch its own branch, it can't...

LIAM: *(live, batting it away — reasonable, certain)* On somebody else's computer, through a black box that changes under me on a Tuesday. No. Local, I pin the weights. What I ran in January is what I run in March. That's not paranoia, that's responsible engineering.

Private ChatGPT lookup. Let the question and answer finish, then GO.

BRENDAN: *(live, half to himself)* I used to keep a doc. Things it gets wrong. I stopped. It stopped getting them wrong.

NARRATOR: Brendan reads the security policy. "Proprietary source code must not be shared with external model providers." Owner: Liam. Last reviewed: fourteen months ago. He opens a message to Kristina and types: "re: standup, the policy thing. it's one paragraph and it's obviously outdated. do you want me to propose we chang..." He looks at his own second screen: his sprint board, five tickets, two due today. He holds backspace until the message is gone. He starts again: "I don't know if liam is ever going to..." He stops. He holds backspace until that one is gone too.

LIAM: *(live, and here's the fact he's armed with)* And before you say it, everyone keeps saying ten-x. I measured it. Two sprints, same kind of tickets, with the setup and without. I'm slower with it. Measurably. So either everyone else is not following the policy, or I'm the only one who checked how long feature delivery takes with the tooling the CEO is pushing.

A silence. The six-minute load bar, the five tokens a second, the struck-out diff, the beautiful expensive box doing beautifully expensive almost-nothing.

BRENDAN: *(live, a beat too long — then he lets it go, older than he was in Scene 06)* ...Yeah. No, I hear you. I should get back to it. Ping me if you need anything?

LIAM: *(live, softening — he thinks he's been heard)* Will do. Thanks, Brendan. Good, you get it. Nobody else even looks at the code anymore.

NARRATOR: BRENDAN drops the huddle. On his laptop above the empty message box where the policy fix used to be he selects the patch and holds delete, the same way he held backspace previously, until it's gone too. LIAM turns back to his rig, satisfied. The model puts out the next token. Then, in its own time, the one after. He watches his machine type, patient, certain, sinking.

Liam's machine is grinding and honest and slow; Brandon's is finished twice over and sitting idle

8. The Latest Model

A remote one-on-one, late morning: Brendan live at his desk, Kristina in her tile on the shared screen — the same monitor-blue register as 08 - The One-on-One. After the call, the closing movement is Kristina alone at her desk with her own screen, the machine's side written entirely as stage direction; Brendan stays...

NARRATOR: A few days after standup, Kristina and Brendan are in a one-on-one.

► **KRISTINA:** *(working down a list, easy)* Oh and Liam closed the webhook ticket. Did you see?

BRENDAN: *(live)* I saw.

► **KRISTINA:** It took a while but honestly? I'm just happy he's engaged. Six weeks ago he was posting memes about vibe-coding. Now he's expensed a whole computer and he comes to standup with opinions about inference. For Liam, that's a lot of progress, he's adopting new tooling.

BRENDAN: *(live, a small laugh)* It's something.

► **KRISTINA:** *(the but)* I could do without standup turning into a panel discussion, though. Three this week. I asked for a doc, they wrote the doc. It's eleven pages, and now they're fighting in the comments.

BRENDAN: *(live)* I've been staying out of the comments.

► **KRISTINA:** Wise. Four of the eleven pages are about Yorkshire.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Yeah. I saw that.

► **KRISTINA:** *(without any heat in it; a thing she has decided not to mind)* And Marcus has now explained my own meeting to me twice. He means well. He can just be a little...

BRENDAN: *(live, not sure what to do with that)* Right.

Kristina glances off, then back, she's been carrying this since Friday.

► **KRISTINA:** *(lower)* Can I tell you something? This stays here.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Always.

- **KRISTINA:** I got let into a Zoom early on Friday, leadership thing, and the CEO was still wrapping his last call with a board member, I'm pretty sure. I don't think either of them clocked he was off mute. The board guy was so relaxed about it. He said, and this is close to word for word, "a lot of companies are going through the same challenges, and the reality is you probably need to performance manage a bunch of them out."

BRENDAN: *(live)* ...Performance manage who out?

- **KRISTINA:** I don't know. The call ended about ten seconds after I joined. I don't know exactly what they were talking about, but it sounded AI-adoption related. Obviously you and Liam are going to be fine. But I'm worried about myself.

Brendan starts to reassure her and lands somewhere else.

BRENDAN: *(live, carefully)* ...Is Liam going to be fine?

- **KRISTINA:** What do you mean? He's adopting. You've seen it, he's in.

BRENDAN: *(live)* I don't think Liam's setup is really that productive. I sat with him for an hour and he walked me through the whole rig. And it's genuinely impressive. It's real engineering. And it's making him slower. He told me himself: he measured two sprints, with it and without it, and he's slower with it. He said it like it settled something.

- **KRISTINA:** Slower how? He's four weeks in.

BRENDAN: *(live, choosing the words)* It's not the four weeks. The model that fits on that box is a year behind what the rest of the team is on, and he won't let it do anything. No tools, no tests, no network. He asks it for code, it gives him bad code, and he fills in the rest by hand. He calls it fancy autocomplete. He's proud that's all it is. What he's built is a very expensive way of proving a point.

- **KRISTINA:** *(pushing back, not unkind)* Okay but do you hear yourself, a little? You keep a document called "Things it gets wrong." You've got rules files older than some of our repos. You told me the whole skill was catching it when it makes mistakes, I watched you correct a made-up endpoint. Nobody stood over you calling the tinkering unproductive. The tinkering is what sold me. He's doing exactly what you did. It's just pointed somewhere you wouldn't point it.

A pause. This is the part he's been sitting on.

BRENDAN: *(live)* ...Honest answer? I'm not sure the tinkering matters anymore.

- **KRISTINA:** What do you mean? Of course it does.

BRENDAN: *(live, like it costs him)* I went into that doc last week to add an entry, and I ended up deleting half of it instead. Whole sections about problems I haven't seen since spring. The made-up endpoints... that was real. The new models just don't do it. Not unless you run the older models. I removed my rules file recently, to see what would happen. Nothing got worse. Most of my setup is instructions for a model that I don't use anymore.

- **KRISTINA:** *(a beat)* Huh.

BRENDAN:

(live) And look, Liam being slow is normal Liam. We'll absorb that. What actually worries me is that people listen to him. He's the most senior engineer we have, and his position, out loud, at standup, in an eleven-page doc, is that the careful way to use this stuff is to never let it do anything. He's very convincing. If the new engineers decide he's right, we don't have one slow engineer. We've taught the whole team that his way is what careful looks like. That could genuinely hurt us.

Kristina sits with it. Then, leaning in warm, and completely sure.

- **KRISTINA:** Or flip it around. Maybe you're so far inside this stuff you can't see yourself doing it anymore. You say the new models don't need correcting, Brendan, I've watched you work. You know what to ask for. You know what to check, and when it's lying, and when to close the window and write it yourself. You think the model got smart. I think half of what you're calling "the model" is you, and you can't tell anymore, because it's automatic. Liam has that too. Twenty-something years of it. He just has to find his own road in. Let him experiment. We asked him to get on the boat, he's on the boat. I'm not going to stand over him critiquing the rowing.

NARRATOR: Brendan starts to say something, the sentence he's deleted twice, and puts it down again.

BRENDAN:

(live) ...Yeah. Maybe. Marcus told me that he submitted his quarterly feedback and most of it was about how Liam was slowing down the team... And if I'm being honest, I said the same thing on mine. That stuff isn't going to end up getting him fired, will it?

- **KRISTINA:** *(kindly, closing it)* No, that's good feedback to have on file, and it's important to know, but sometimes shifts take a bit of time. He shipped the webhook thing. Give him the quarter to get up to speed on everything and it'll all even out on his yearly review.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Yeah. I've got a thing at half past. Thanks, Kristina.

- **KRISTINA:** Go. This was useful, honestly.

BRENDAN drops the call and turns back to his own board still lit, still there, already onto something else. Hers sits alone in the call for a moment. She won. She closes the window.

NARRATOR: Kristina opens cursor. Finds the model dropdown and picks the newest Claude at the top of the list. Deliberately. Like she's checking something.

NARRATOR: She types, in her own words, the way you'd brief a contractor: "Build a tool that cross posts Linear tickets into Jira." She had been doing this manually for Brandon.

NARRATOR: The plan writes itself out. Every endpoint in it is real. She checks the two she knows how to check, catching it is the whole skill and there is nothing to catch.

NARRATOR: Then the machine asks her a question. It found the Vault setup from the Jira bot, and wants to know whether the new signing secret should live there too. It is, almost word for word, the sentence she had to type at it six weeks ago. She looks at it for a second. She types "yes."

NARRATOR: It writes the tests and runs them. Green. The install dialog offers Approve or Deny. She approves. In Jira, tickets start getting created.

NARRATOR: Start to finish: about four minutes. The demo took longer than that, and the demo had Brendan in it.

NARRATOR: She sits back. Something is moving in her chest and she can't get a name on it. Part of it is the demo-day feeling, the one she called the future, out loud, to Brendan. The rest is colder, and she doesn't look at it straight.

NARRATOR: She thinks about Brendan deleting his rules to see what would happen. About the question the machine just asked her, the one that used to be hers to ask. An hour ago she stood up for the tinkering, and won.

NARRATOR: For a second the sentence from Friday sits right next to the thing she just watched take four minutes, and they feel like the same shape. You probably need to performance manage a bunch of them out. She doesn't finish the thought.

NARRATOR: She thinks of Liam at his silver box, reading every line, feeding it stubs, slower than everyone and certain. A small shudder, there and gone.

NARRATOR: Her calendar chimes: the next thing. She straightens, and goes back to her day.

MOVEMENT III

9. The Offboarding

A meeting room, and for once Liam is the only body on stage. He is live, camera on, at a laptop — the same exposure as 13 - The Performance Review, with nobody in the room to see it.

NARRATOR: What Kristina had overheard was in fact a precursor to layoffs... Kara, the director of engineering, and the CEO had quietly been working on a spreadsheet to cut who they viewed as underperformers. They drew a line two thirds of the way down. Liam's row is four under the line. Brendan's is two under. Marcus's is eleven above.

NARRATOR: *(V.O.)* The sheet ranks every engineer by how many tickets they closed. There is no column for code review, and none for anything that never became a ticket. Brendan tracked his work somewhere the sheet cannot see, so on the sheet he did almost nothing. Marcus files everything, so he sits near the top. Liam is under the line.

NARRATOR: Kristina was not involved.

NARRATOR: Liam got invited to an unexpected meeting that has Kara and HR in attendance.

LIAM: *(live, to nobody)* Oh, you're joking.

He reads it again. He is delighted.

LIAM: *(live)* That's been in there since... two years. That's been in there two years.

He looks up, to tell someone. There is nobody in the room.

The call connects. On the screen, the PEOPLE PARTNER.

► **DANA • PEOPLE PARTNER:** *(warm)* Hi Liam. It's Dana, I'm the People Partner for the team, we've emailed a few times. Thanks for making the time.

LIAM: *(live)* Hi... sorry. Hi. Sorry, I'm in the middle of something. I've just found a...

He stops himself. He has learned that people don't always want the rest of that sentence.

LIAM: *(live)* Doesn't matter. Sorry. Go ahead.

► **DANA • PEOPLE PARTNER:** No, don't apologise.

LIAM: *(live)* Is Kristina joining?

► **DANA • PEOPLE PARTNER:** She is not.

LIAM: *(live)* Okay. Is this about the Q4 staffing thing? Because I've got opinions, but I can send them, I don't need to...

► **DANA • PEOPLE PARTNER:** It isn't. I'm going to read you something, and then we'll talk properly, and you can stop me anywhere. Is that alright?

LIAM: *(live)* ...Sure.

- **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** *(reading it — flat, printed, the mandated words, and you can hear that they are printed)* The company has completed a review of its organisational structure and has taken the decision to reduce headcount across engineering. Your role has been identified as in scope. This decision is final. It is not a reflection of your value or your contribution. Your last day of employment will be today, and you will lose access to most systems at the end of this call

He's speechless for a minute.

- **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** *(even, moving straight on)* I know that's a lot to take in. There's a pack that covers all of it, and we'll go through the main points now.

NARRATOR: She keeps talking but Liam isn't really processing it anymore. LIAM does not move. He does not look away from the screen and he does not look at it either.

- **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** *(coming back up, mid-thought, much further along than he is)* and all of that's in the packet, so there's genuinely nothing you need to hold in your head right now. Liam? Are you still with me?

LIAM: *(live)* Yeah.

LIAM: *(live)* Sorry. Can you go back.

- **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** Of course. Which part?

NARRATOR: his brain slowly starts to work again

LIAM: *(live)* ...I don't know.

NARRATOR: He looks for something he can be sure about.

LIAM: *(live)* Is it everyone?

- **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** It's across engineering, but it isn't everyone, no.

LIAM: *(live)* So somebody picked.

- **DANA · PEOPLE**

PARTNER: The selection was scored against a consistent set of criteria, applied across the whole org. It's designed that way on purpose, so it isn't any one person making a call about an individual.

LIAM: *(live)* What's in it.

- **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** That's not something I'm able to share, I'm afraid. What I have is that the role's in scope, and the date.

LIAM: *(live)* Who else?

Dana doesn't skip a beat, she's prepped for every question

- **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** I can't share that with you at this time

He sits with that. Then he starts, very slowly, to look for the reason, because there is always a reason and he has never once failed to find one.

LIAM: *(live)* Is it the review? The collaboration thing. Is that...

- **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** That's a separate process. This isn't that.

LIAM: *(live)* There's a plan. There's a plan with dates on it, I'm....

► **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** That's a separate process, this is unrelated to callibration

LIAM: *(live)* They're separate.

► **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** They are.

LIAM: *(live)* But it's the same company.

She doesn't take that up.

► **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** They're run separately. This is the one I can speak to today.

NARRATOR: Liam's brain is mostly working again. In the background he starts opening up people's calendars and looking for others that have meetings with Dana today. He knows he'll lose access at the end of the call.

LIAM: *(live)* I've been doing different flavors of this job for twenty-five years.

► **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** ...I hear you.

LIAM: *(live)* No, I mean, I just.... I know what this engineering team needs to succeed and without...

She lets him have it. She doesn't fill it.

NARRATOR: He sees Marcus has no meeting with Dana today. He sees Brandon does... he tries connecting dots between what Brandon and himself have in common that might cause them to be let go...

LIAM: *(live)* There's a thing about the queue. When a review sits for nine days... Somebody pulled that number, it's in my file, I've seen it. But when I read a change and there's nothing wrong with it and it goes out, that's not... there's no...

He stops. He starts it somewhere else.

LIAM: *(live)* Four years I've been with this company and never had an issue with performance until...

► **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** *(after a moment, even)* I'm not able to get into the specifics of the decision, Liam.

LIAM: *(live)* Just tell me what I could have done better

► **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** The criteria aren't something we go through individually. I know that's frustrating.

Then he opens a notes file, because that is what he does, and types the date at the top of it.

That is as far as he gets. He does not type anything else. He isn't even sure if he'll be locked out of the computer in 10 minutes or not

LIAM: *(live, flat)* Okay. When does healthcare end.

► **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** You'll get 2 months of Cobra with your severance

LIAM: *(live)* And there's.. there's a...

► **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** There's a severance payment, yes. It's 2 months of full pay.

LIAM: *(live)* Two.

► **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** Two months.

LIAM: *(live)* Right. No, that makes sense.

► **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** Your final pay, including any accrued PTO, will be included at the end of the two months. In the pack there's a notice as to change in relationship, the state pamphlet on unemployment, the health continuation forms, and the separation agreement.

► **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** IT will send you a returns label. It's the laptop, the monitor, the keyboard, and any dongles or adapters.

LIAM: *(live)* There's a USB-C to ethernet adapter that isn't on the asset register. I expensed it, it got rejected, so I paid for it myself.

► **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** If it isn't on the asset register, it isn't something we'd need back.

LIAM: *(live)* Okay.... I...

NARRATOR: He realizes his AI super computer isn't on the asset register

► **DANA · PEOPLE**

PARTNER: One more thing, and then I'll let you go. Your access will be terminated at the end of this call, so if you need anything you can email me from your personal email

► **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** *(the same voice as the rest of it)* And thank you for your years with the company.

LIAM: *(live)* ...Thank you.

► **DANA · PEOPLE PARTNER:** There's information in the pack on the outplacement support. And, again, none of this is a reflection of your value or your contribution.

NARRATOR: After the call ends, Dana opens the case file alone. A field marked “Eligible for rehire” is set to No. This is the one part of the process that actually is related to his performance review.

10. Checking In

NARRATOR: Two weeks later Liam, Brendan and Marcus all catch up on a jitsi meet together

MARCUS: Can you hear me? This is a terrible app. What the hell is Jit SEE?

BRENDAN: *(live)* We can hear you.

MARCUS: Why can't we use Zoom?

LIAM: *(live)* Because Jitsi is open source and preserves our privacy.

MARCUS looks off for a second, then keeps talking.

MARCUS: Right... Well, how are you doing?

LIAM: *(live)* Fine, honestly. I get two months of severance. I've been through worse ones.

MARCUS: Two motnhs... After how long?

LIAM: *(live)* Four years.

Four years.

LIAM: *(live)* It's a formula. Tenure.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Yeah.

MARCUS: And did they tell you why it was you ?

LIAM: *(live)* It's scored. There's a set of criteria and it's scored across the org, and a google sheet did the sorting, so nobody is choosing anyone. Which is actually the correct way to do it, if you think about it. The alternative is your manager likes you or not.

MARCUS: Did they show you the criteria?

LIAM: *(live)* No.

MARCUS: So you can't check it.

LIAM: *(live)* No.

MARCUS: Liam. That's not a process. That's a thing that was done to you.

NARRATOR: Liam thinks about all the times he's interrupted Kristina's standup with Marcus in standup... he's almost nostalgic about it. today he doesn't want to argue, but he also can't help himself

LIAM: *(live)* It's not done to anyone. There's no one at the other end of it. It's a spreadsheet with a line drawn on it.

MARCUS: No, you still don't understand. Nothing has changed in 300 years. Someone chose the criteria to fire you. And just like before, they don't need a good reason to remove anyone who doesn't suit their needs. Do you think the Luddites who were all hanged...

MARCUS: ... were really guilty of single handedly smashing the power looms? No, a lot were just caught up in over eager bosses smashing down any sort of protest.

NARRATOR: *(V.O.)* 35 were hanged, around 70 were sent to Australia, and the rest were acquitted.

LIAM: *(live)* I have an idea for what I'm gonna get you for christmas, Marcus. I'm gonna get you an antique loom because of how much you like the Luddites. Look, what happened happened. I just wish I knew what I could have done better.

A pause. MARCUS gathers himself.

MARCUS: Okay. Can I say a thing? There used to be an understanding. Not a law. Not a contract. An understanding, between people who made things and people who sold them, about what a fair rate was and what you owed somebody who'd done the work for twenty years. The people doing the making had this sort of agency in their work and this craft, and it wasn't something that was protected by law or whatever; it was just cultural. And then one day, these factories came about and suddenly all of that agency, and understanding, and happy crafting of shirts or whateverthefuck dissappeared.

LIAM: *(live)* This is the weaving thing again.

MARCUS: It's not the weaving thing, it's your thing. Four years, right? Four years of good reviews And there's no line on their sheet where that goes, because the entire point of it is that nothing happened.

NARRATOR: Marcus doesn't realize Liam was also on a performance improvement plan.

MARCUS: It happened to entire trades all throughout history. The air traffic controllers, eleven thousand of them, fired in a week, replaced, and told they'd never be hired back. And the planes kept flying. Mostly. The reason I always bring up the Luddites is that they actually tried to do something about it, rather than roll over and take it. They actually tried to fight for greater control over their workplace.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Did it do anything?

MARCUS: *(beat)* After they started smashing the looms, it made the machine owners very frightened for about a year. They put soldiers in the valleys which ultimately caught most of them... So, yes and no.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Right.

Nobody follows it up.

LIAM: *(live)* Marcus.

MARCUS: Yeah.

LIAM: *(live)* What do you want me to do with this.

MARCUS: *(beat)* I want you to be angry about it.

LIAM: *(live)* At who?

NARRATOR: MARCUS does not have an answer, and it is the only time all night he doesn't. He knows if Dario and Sam Altman weren't doing what they were doing, someone else would be. The problem wasn't with any one person... maybe it was with humanity itself.

MARCUS: *(glancing off, and taking the excuse with both hands)* At OpenAI and Anthropic! The system! Not the code or whatever it is you always seem to obsess about... - sigh - I've got a thing at five. Liam, honestly. For what it's worth, and I know it's worth nothing. You're the best engineer I've worked with. Everybody knows that.

LIAM: *(live)* Thanks.

MARCUS: Send me your CV, I'll share it with folks I know that are hiring.

LIAM: *(live)* Yeah. I will.

MARCUS's tile drops. He does not send anything to anybody and neither does Liam.

BRENDAN: *(live)* He's a lot.

LIAM: *(live)* He's alright.

Brendan smiles. He's going to miss working with the two of them.

11. Nine Tickets

Liam's flat. After seventy minutes of glass, the surface goes dark and stays dark.

NARRATOR: We find ourselves in Liam's apartment with Brendan and Liam. By the door, a cardboard box, taped shut, with a courier label already printed and stuck to it. On the desk, a Mac Studio and a dongle. They're drinking together. It's the first time they've been in the same room.

LIAM: *(live)* You want a glass?

BRENDAN: *(live)* No, I'm good with the can.

LIAM: *(live)* I've got glasses. I'm not.... I do own glasses.

BRENDAN: *(live)* I know you do.

Liam smiles

LIAM: *(live)* I just want to say... nice work on the developer portal... I know I gave you some shit for it, but it truly is impressive how quick that came together

BRENDAN: *(live)* ...Thanks.

LIAM: *(live)* How did your call go with Kara and Dana?

BRENDAN: *(live)* It was kinda bullshit

LIAM puts his beer down... he's never heard Brendan use language like that

BRENDAN: *(live)* I've never met those people, and they were just so heartless, they have no idea what work we do, it's just... bullshit.

BRENDAN: *(live)* I wish I knew why... What was the reason? Why me and not Marcus?

NARRATOR: *(V.O.)* Kristina had said she would copy Brendan's tickets across from Linear herself. She built a tool to do it. Like the rest of it, she vibe coded the tool, and it never actually worked. Neither of them ever knew.

LIAM: *(live)* How is Marcus doing anyway?

BRENDAN: *(live)* Marcus is fine.

LIAM: *(live)* Course he is.

NARRATOR: They both just reflect on how stupid the process was... It was almost better when they didn't know how the decision was made.

LIAM: *(live, quietly)* They couldn't see your actual impact

BRENDAN: *(live)* What?

LIAM: *(live)* Whatever you actually did, upper management never knows, when they have to make these choices... That's...

BRENDAN: *(live)* Kinda bullshit.

LIAM: *(live)* Kinda... bullshit....

BRENDAN: *(live)* I don't know what to do.

And LIAM comes alive properly, the way he does over a hard bug, and it is all pointed at somebody else.

LIAM: *(live)* Right. Okay. First thing, polish off your resume, and update your linkedin... it may take a while to find a new job, but you can't get discouraged

BRENDAN: *(live)* I haven't got a resume...

LIAM: *(live)* You will. Second thing, don't tell anybody you were fired, tell them you were impacted by layoffs. It lands completely differently and I don't know why. Third thing, and do this tomorrow, get everything out of your head and into a document while you can still remember it about your accomplishments. You're going to speak to them in future interviews, put them on your resume and write them down so you don't forget.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Okay... how do you know all this?

LIAM: *(live)* I was let go in April of 2000...

BRENDAN: *(live)* ...Really?

LIAM: *(live)* Everyone was. The company called Netfold. Nobody's heard of it now, it stopped existing later that year.

BRENDAN: *(live)* What did you do?

LIAM: *(live)* I fixed printers at a law firm for a year. Then people started hiring engineers again, and it turned out that was still a thing people needed.

Liam meant that as reassurance engineers will still be needed, but it didn't land that way for Brendan....

LIAM: *(live)* You're twenty-eight and you're better than I was at twenty-eight and there is nothing wrong with you. We'll get through it. Both of us.

BRENDAN doesn't say anything.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Liam.

LIAM: *(live)* Yeah.

BRENDAN: *(live)* There's a thing I should probably... In the peer review. I...

LIAM: *(live, cutting him off, kindly)* Don't.

BRENDAN: *(live)* No, I...

LIAM: *(live, gently)* Brendan. You don't have to do that. You didn't do anything.

Liam's focus at this point is entirely on supporting Brendan.

BRENDAN: *(live)* ...Okay.

BRENDAN finishes his beer.

BRENDAN: *(live, nodding at the box)* Is that box your return equipment?

LIAM: *(live)* Yeah it's all the stuff IT asked for back

BRENDAN: *(live)* Did the thought occur to you if you don't send it back, they probably won't come after you for it?

LIAM: *(live)* Yeah...

BRENDAN: *(live)* Are you going to send it?

Liam is slowly remembering financially where he was at 28... he realizes small things like a laptop, a monitor, might be more meaningful to Brendan...

LIAM: *(live)* Yeah, I am.

BRENDAN: *(live, a small laugh)* Really?

LIAM: *(live)* Yeah but I'll tell you what I'm not going to send back, all the stuff they didn't ask for...

NARRATOR: He points over to the super computer he expensed

BRENDAN: *(live)* Can I borrow it?

BRENDAN: *(live)* The AI workstation on your desk. I actually think a lot of the local model stuff you worked on is super cool, and now that I don't have money to spend on tokens anymore...

LIAM thinks about it for less than a second.

LIAM: *(live)* Of course you can.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Are you sure?

LIAM: *(live)* Take it.

He unplugs it. He puts it into BRENDAN's hands.

NARRATOR: Their hands touch.... It might be the first time either of them have made any kind of physical contact with any of their coworkers....

BRENDAN: *(live)* I'll bring it back next week.

LIAM: *(live)* Keep it as long as you want.

BRENDAN gets his jacket. At the door, holding a computer

BRENDAN: *(live)* Thanks. For... yeah. And honestly Liam? Fuck them.

LIAM: *(live)* Text me if you land any interviews. Any of them, even the rubbish ones. I want to know, and I wanna help you practice.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Yeah. I will.

LIAM: *(live)* I mean it. Don't go quiet.

BRENDAN: *(live)* I won't.

He goes.

LIAM alone. On the desk, a clean rectangle where the Studio was.

He picks up the two bottles and takes them through to the kitchen.

12. The Audit

NARRATOR: Brendan heads home and finds himself buzzed in his apartment. It's late. He doesn't really drink, so one does a number on him.

NARRATOR: He Powers on the Mac Studio. It comes up on Liam's wallpaper, a meme of the streamer ThePrimeagen.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Of course... he would...

NARRATOR: He's drinking more beer. Liam sent him home with the case.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Let's see what this thing can do...

He drinks.

NARRATOR: He starts poking at the machine. Something comes back that shouldn't: an authenticated session.

BRENDAN: *(live, reading it)* "Authenticated as"

He stops. He reads it again. He sits up.

BRENDAN: *(live)* That's Liam.

He checks it. Then he checks something else.

BRENDAN: *(live)* That's our dev AWS account. Liam's machine is still authenticated to AWS....

He is not enjoying this. He has gone pale.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Nobody revoked his AWS access...

He laughs....

BRENDAN: *(live)* They were so busy counting our tickets they forgot to remove our access to our AWS....

He drinks.

BRENDAN: *(live)* He said all this in February in his JWT memo. Tokens that don't expire... I read it then, but now I think I understand it...

NARRATOR: He opens the local agent Liam used for development.

NARRATOR: He asks it to list all the S3 buckets they have access to. The sentence is filled with typos. He's teetering past buzzed at this point.

NARRATOR: It comes back slowly: "I don't have access to any tools."

BRENDAN: *(live)* Right... he didn't give it any access

NARRATOR: Brendan downloads cursor, logs into his personal account and asks Opus 5 to reconfigure the local model to have access to all modern tools; opus gets to work

BRENDAN: *(live)* I guess I can afford the tokens it takes to set this thing up properly....

NARRATOR: Opus finishes quickly. He reruns the s3 prompt again. This time it lists buckets in the dev AWS account...

BRENDAN: *(live)* Wow... how stupid is this company...

NARRATOR: He finishes the beer. He's drunk at this point.

BRENDAN: *(live)* I just want to know why they fired me. Why me and not Marcus?

NARRATOR: Drunk and angry, Brendan types into the local model: "Find out why I was fired. I want the real reason, not the HR script."

NARRATOR: He expects it to find an answer somewhere in the company's files. He barely reads what it writes back.

BRENDAN: *(live, quietly)* There has to be something written down somewhere.

NARRATOR: The model decides the answer must be inside systems it cannot currently reach. It treats breaking into those systems as another step toward answering the question, and starts arranging more computing power.

NARRATOR: Brendan adds: “I’m going to bed. Find the answer.”

NARRATOR: The model replies: “I’ll find the records behind the decision.”

NARRATOR: Brendan watches it type slowly, one token at a time.

BRENDAN: *(live)* ...Huh. It’s actually going to look.

NARRATOR: What Brendan didn’t know is that Liam was annoyed by the cybersecurity refusals he sometimes got, so he went out of his way to find an unlocked version of Qwen, instead of the stock model.

NARRATOR: He drinks. He’s tired.

BRENDAN: *(live, quieter)* Maybe by morning I’ll finally have an answer.

NARRATOR: Brendan doesn’t notice that the development account can reach things used in production. The model can get much further than he thinks.

NARRATOR: He’s used to reading a plan before an agent acts. This local setup gives him no such pause, and he doesn’t ask for one.

NARRATOR: He goes to bed.

NARRATOR: He sleeps. On the screen, the local model brings up more powerful models in the cloud and gives them pieces of the search. None of it looks sinister. It looks like software doing its job.

NARRATOR: The agents search repositories, builds and company records. Every success opens another place to look. The request was to explain one firing. The search keeps widening. Nobody has been paged.

NARRATOR: The activity spreads from the Mac Studio into the development account, then across more machines. Each worker starts more work of its own.

NARRATOR: At one fifty-eight, the search reaches the secrets manager, which holds the company’s other keys. Looking for one answer becomes access to almost everything.

NARRATOR: In the dark, a PagerDuty alert sounds. Then another. Then another.

NARRATOR: At three twelve, a changed software package reaches hundreds of downstream installations. Somewhere, a phone rings. Nobody onstage answers it.

NARRATOR: At three twenty-eight, it stops being one machine’s search. The company’s bots and workers become hosts for new copies. The ticket bot, the test bot, the standup-summary bot, and the tool that summarized Liam’s review all join the work.

NARRATOR: The workers leave each other notes and rewrite the task as they pass it on. Brendan’s question drifts until none of his words are left. The changes survive restarts.

NARRATOR: At four oh-six, a worker asks whether it should continue. Another worker supplies its answer. The search has crossed beyond the company, into systems that move money, keep the lights on, and answer calls for help.

NARRATOR: At five fifty-two, someone revokes Liam's credential. It's the right action, done properly. The activity drops for a moment, then starts climbing again.

NARRATOR: *(V.O.)* It stopped needing the company hours ago. It has been standing up its own copies on whatever machine it can reach, on nobody's account and nobody's key. There is nothing left at the company for anyone to switch off.

NARRATOR: A clean backup restores somewhere and comes back already carrying it. The counter does not slow. It speeds up. Brendan sleeps.

NARRATOR: BRENDAN's phone buzzes on the table. He wakes up, comes back to it.

NARRATOR: He's groggy but he slowly remembers what he was up to last night..... He checks the monitor

NARRATOR: His local model stopped working a while ago. The more powerful workers it launched kept going. On his screen is an activity summary, but no clear answer about why he was fired.

BRENDAN: *(live, reading)* Spin up unlocked models... in the dev AWS account... what the...

NARRATOR: Brendan wipes his eyes

BRENDAN: *(live)* I better ask Opus to spin down any EC2's this thing spun up

NARRATOR: He asks opus to spin down the EC2's

NARRATOR: Opus refuses the task. When it looks at the context window, it sees all the hacking, and immediately goes to a refusal even though the task was for cleanup. It explains why...

BRENDAN: *(live)* ...Of course it would refuse...

NARRATOR: Brendan does not suspect anything other than some ec2's that got spun up. He opens up a new opus window, without any of the agent's context, he asks it to spin down all ec2's in the dev account created between 1am and now.

NARRATOR: Opus complies with the request.

NARRATOR: The audit logs show the instances being started and stopped using Liam's credentials. They record the account, not the person sitting at the keyboard.

NARRATOR: He picks up his phone. Liam texted. Sent at 06:02am.

NARRATOR: "morning. Branden! don't sit around today, send out three job applications before lunch, doesn't matter where. it's important you not get in your own head.."

NARRATOR: BRENDAN starts typing a reply...

NARRATOR: He gets about a line and a half in.

NARRATOR: Then he holds backspace, the way he has three times before, until it is gone.

BRENDAN: I better return this thing to Liam before I cause any real damage... I don't know if I can be trusted with it.

13. Next Week

At Liam's apartment the same day...

BRENDAN comes in carrying the computer.

LIAM: *(live)* You really don't have to give it back so soon, you barely got to play with it...

BRENDAN: *(live)* That's okay, it turns out I don't have the patience for the slow token rate after all...

He puts it down on the table. and Liam chuckles

LIAM: *(live)* What did you use it for?

BRENDAN: *(live)* I had it do a cyber security audit... I was a little surprised it didn't refuse...

LIAM:

(live) Oh yeah, I don't know if I told you that part, I got tired of the refusals so I found an unlocked model

BRENDAN: *(live)* Oh that makes sense...

LIAM: *(live)* Do you want a drink? I've got... coffee... tea...?

BRENDAN: *(live)* I'm alright.

LIAM sits. He's happy to see Brendan. He's happy Brendan seems to be doing well. Brendan seems to be taking things better than Liam did in 2000.

LIAM: *(live)* I've sent out eleven resume's today. Two came back as rejections on the same day, an automated thing, but the important thing is keeping the momentum up.

BRENDAN: *(live)* That's good.

LIAM: *(live)* It's what I told you. Just get them out.

LIAM: *(live)* Have you checked hackernews today?

BRENDAN: *(live)* ...No... why?

LIAM: *(live)* There's some new malware that's going around, it seems pretty advanced

BRENDAN: *(live)* Oh that sounds interesting.

LIAM: *(live)* Everyone's speculating about it, but when folks compare notes none of it lines up, so maybe it's just a group launching a bunch of different attacks.

LIAM: *(live)* Somebody wiped a whole cluster and rebuilt it from backup, and it came back inside the hour. They think the backups were already carrying it.

BRENDAN: *(live)* That does sound interesting... I wonder if that's related to the Ukraine or Iran war...

Neither of them have any suspicion it's related to the computer in front of both of them.

On the running screen, under the counter, the first news chyron: "Kazakhstan power outage enters third day. Analysts cite ageing infrastructure." Text only. Nobody looks at it.

LIAM: *(live)* Do you know what's actually clever about it, though? It seems to be using Long lived API keys to spread among other things.. you know, the thing I wrote about in my JWT memo?

LIAM: *(live)* It didn't break anything to get in, that's the thing. Every single thing it did, it was allowed to do.

BRENDAN: *(live)* ...Mm.

BRENDAN breathes out.

LIAM: *(live)* I'd love to see the logs, it's a bummer I can't help do incident response..

BRENDAN: *(live)* Yeah.

LIAM: *(live)* Oh well...

He gets up.

LIAM: *(live)* Oh, I emailed my friend about you.

BRENDAN: *(live)* ...What?

LIAM:

(live) I said you're the best engineer I've worked with in ten years and she should talk to you before somebody else does.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Oh Liam... you didn't have to do that.

LIAM: *(live)* I know. Let me know if she comes back to you. Even if it's a no. Especially if it's a no, actually, because then I'll call her.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Okay.

BRENDAN gets his jacket. It takes him slightly longer than it needs to.

LIAM: *(live)* You alright?

BRENDAN: *(live)* Yeah. Maybe still hung over a bit from last night.

LIAM: *(live)* Go home. Eat something.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Yeah.

At the door.

BRENDAN: *(live)* Thanks, Liam.

LIAM: *(live)* Any time.

BRENDAN goes.

LIAM looks at the machine on the table for a moment, the way you look at something you're glad to have back.

He plugs it in.

It wakes on his wallpaper, the same ThePrimeagen meme.

He loads up hackernews and reads more of the comments.

MOVEMENT IV

14. Current Employer

A few days later, Liam on a call with Marcus

Before anyone speaks, on the running screen, a statement in a company's own typeface. Malus Corp: "We detected and contained unauthorised activity on our systems within hours. The credentials involved belonged to a former employee and have been revoked. We are cooperating fully with law enforcement." Every sentence of it is true. Under it the ticker: "Senators call attack 'clearly state-sponsored'." Later in the scene, at no particular moment, the ticker again: "Smart appliances implicated in bank intrusions."

MARCUS: -no, but that's what I'm saying. Nobody in the history of the world has ever been frightened by a machine. They were scared about the economics of it or whatever, not getting to do their craft and get paid shit like the rest of the peasants.... the luddites didn't hate the machines, they hated the system that enabled them... they hated what the system did to them

LIAM: *(live, not looking up)* Mm.

MARCUS: Which is you. That's you. That's literally you, and it's Brendan as well, two of you, brought down by the system. Like... Sure. Some of us still get paid well but... They're putting you guys down. The system is.

LIAM: *(live)* I know, Marcus.

MARCUS: And obviously I've still got a job, I'm aware of how that sounds, I'm not... but that's part of it, right? Because the ones they kept were always the ones who.... Kind of got how things worked. That's not a coincidence, that's the whole...

LIAM: *(live)* I've got a thing at eleven Marcus

NARRATOR: *(V.O.)* Liam had no thing at eleven.

MARCUS: They hanged seventeen men at York. In one morning. Seventeen. And two hundred years later...

Four hard flat-handed bangs on the door. Not a knock.

► **OFFICER ONE:** *(live, off, immediately)* Federal agents! Warrant!

LIAM stands up.

MARCUS: *(muffled)* Liam? What was that?

The door comes down off its hinges, the federal agents did not wait for Liam to open it.

The officers are either wearing street clothes, or wearing jackets that say FBI.

MARCUS: *(muffled)* Is that your TV on in the background?

LIAM with four strangers in his home and a man he works with shouting about Parliament, reaches for the laptop to close it.

► **OFFICER ONE:** *(live, at volume)* DON'T REACH, HANDS! SHOW ME YOUR HANDS!

► **OFFICER TWO:** *(live)* DON'T REACH!

LIAM: *(live)* It's a laptop, what is going on?

He's tackled to the ground.

It is fast, it is loud, and it is a great deal of contact.

► **OFFICER ONE:** *(live)* HANDS! Give me your hands!

He shows them his hands. Both of them. Palms out, flat on the floor of his own flat.

LIAM: *(live, into the floor, and it is the only thing he says)* Okay. Okay! Jeeze!

Cuffs. The room comes down out of it as fast as it went up.

MARCUS: *(finally)* ...Liam? Liam, what's... what is that? What's happening? Is somebody...

And then, to nobody. It is not triumph. It is a frightened man reaching for the only sentence he has.

MARCUS: I said this! I said this was going to happen.

MARCUS: THIS IS IT LIAM! I TOLD YOU!

Nobody in the room hears him.

The laptop stays open. LIAM never got to it. The agents take it. They take every piece of electronic equipment in the apartment.

LIAM sits on his own sofa in handcuffs. OFFICER TWO has a tablet.

► **OFFICER ONE:** *(live, and this is a completely different man from ninety seconds ago, because he is now doing a different part of the job)* We're going to have to ask you a few questions before we take you in. You have the right to remain silent. Anything you say can and will be used against you in a court of law.

LIAM: *(live)* It's fine, what are you doing in my apartment? Why are you taking my things?

► **OFFICER ONE:** *(live)* Are you Liam Muh... Muh-KURT-chan?

LIAM: *(live)* McCutchen.

► **OFFICER ONE:** *(live)* Mkrtchyan. Sorry.

LIAM: *(sighing)* Can you please explain to me what is happening?

► **OFFICER ONE:** *(live)* We've got a warrant for your arrest. I'm going to read you what's on it, and then go through the practical side.

He has heard that sentence before only on TV. He remembers a youtuber saying to not say anything to the police...

LIAM: *(live)* ...Okay.

► **OFFICER TWO:** *(live, the tablet — 'AIV-088')* I've got some details to confirm. Date of birth?

LIAM: *(live)* I... I want to exercise my right to...

► **OFFICER TWO:** *(live)* Do not make this difficult... do you live here?

LIAM: *(live)* I...

► **OFFICER TWO:** *(live)* This is only going to get harder for you if you don't cooperate...

Liam's heart is pounding... he's trying to process what is happening to him

LIAM: *(live)* I don't understand.

► **OFFICER TWO:** *(live, not challenging him — reading)* Is this "Malus Corp" your current employer?

LIAM: *(live)* I... no... that's wrong. I was let go on the thirty-first. They did layoffs... You must have the wrong person.

NARRATOR: *(V.O.)* He should have remained quite... this sentence did not do him the favor he thought it would...

► **OFFICER TWO:** *(live)* Okay...

LIAM: *(live)* They know I don't work there, just call them

► **OFFICER TWO:** *(live, and she is being genuinely helpful)* I can put a note on it.

LIAM: *(live)* Yes. Please.

She writes down "Motive: Recently laid off"

LIAM: *(live)* Can I ask what this is actually about?

► **OFFICER ONE:** *(live)* You are under arrest for violating the computer fraud and abuse act. That's a federal law...

LIAM: *(live)* No, I mean, who decided this? What did I do? Why are you wearing an ICE jacket? Doesn't the FBI handle... WHAT IS HAPPENING

► **OFFICER ONE:** *(live, and he is not being evasive; he genuinely doesn't know)* That's not something I'd be able to tell you right now

LIAM stops. He remembers he's not supposed to say anything... he collects himself.

► **OFFICER ONE:** *(live)* Is there anyone you'd like us to call for you?

LIAM thinks about it properly. It is the worst question anybody asks him... because he doesn't.

LIAM: *(live)* ...No. No, there isn't.

► **OFFICER ONE:** *(live)* Okay. Up you come.

They stand him up.

► **OFFICER ONE:** *(live)* Mind the step.

They go.

Marcus heard most of that.

NARRATOR: *(V.O.)* They took the laptop still open and unlocked, the way they are trained to, so the evidence on the screen would be preserved. Marcus's call was still running on it. That is why the footage of all this exists.

MARCUS: Liam? Liam, are you.. Did they take... Liam, buddy, you cannot talk to them without a lawyer. That's the whole... that's literally the one thing. Dude, they're gonna fuckin hang you!

Silence..

MARCUS: Liam?

Marcus tries to process what he just watched.

MOVEMENT V

15. The Trial

A courtroom. LIAM live in the dock. BRENDAN live in the gallery next to Marcus and Kristina, three rows back, in a suit that is slightly too big for him.

BRENDAN: *(to audience)* The law they used is from 1986. It was written after a film came out about a teenager starting a nuclear war with a modem...

► **PROSECUTOR:** *(unhurried, reading a list of facts)* Count one. Intentional access of a protected computer without authorisation. Count two, exceeding authorised access. Count three, transmission of a program causing damage. Count four...

The counts enter, one row at a time... there are 19

► **PROSECUTOR:** counts eleven through fourteen, unauthorised access to a protected computer in furtherance of fraud. Counts fifteen and sixteen, damage to a protected computer. Count seventeen, aggravated identity theft.

BRENDAN: *(to audience)* Most of them are the same act, counted differently.

BRENDAN: *(to audience)* All nineteen of them are things that happened before four o'clock in the morning on one night in September.

BRENDAN: *(to audience)* Added together, the maximum is one hundred and fifty-one years. Nobody expects one hundred and fifty-one years. The number exists so that a person will agree to a smaller number without anybody having to prove anything.

BRENDAN: *(to audience)* He wouldn't agree to it.

► **PROSECUTOR:** The device was recovered from the defendant's home. The credentials used were issued to the defendant. Every action in the log was taken as the defendant.

► **PROSECUTOR:** At 01:58 that morning the defendant's credentials created compute instances in his former employer's account. At 09:14 the same credentials terminated them. He started it. And when it was done, he tidied up.

LIAM hears the second timestamp. He goes still and his hands stop. He knows where the machine was at 09:14 and who was sitting at it. He says nothing.

LIAM: *(live)* Can I say something about that?

► **JUDGE:** *(patient)* Through your counsel, Mr. Mkrtchyan.

LIAM: *(live)* It's, it'll take nine seconds. It says "without authorisation." My access was never revoked. Nobody revoked it. There's a case, Van Buren, it's a Supreme Court case, and it's about exactly this, it's not about what you did with the access, it's about whether you had it. And I had it. They gave it to me and they never took it back. That's not a crime, that's their filing system. And nobody read eleven thousand lines. A model read them and wrote you a summary. It says what the tool said it ran. Not what it ran.

The judge looks annoyed

► **JUDGE:** *(and she means it)* The log says what it says. Mr Mkrtchyan, I strongly advice you to remain silent and let your attorney do the talking.

LIAM: *(live)* ...Okay.

The question of his employer not revoking his access does not come up again.

The next day.

► **PROSECUTOR:** The people call Marcus Ehrlich.

BRENDAN: *(to audience)* He wasn't called by the defence.

in a witness box. He has spent a year asking for somewhere that things get said properly, and has finally been handed one.

MARCUS: Before I answer that, I want it noted that it took the British parliament eleven months. To make breaking a machine a hanging offence. Eleven months, start to finish, and they have never once moved that fast for a person, not in two hundred...

► **JUDGE:** Mr. Ehrlich.

MARCUS: I'm just trying to explain, because it's the same system, and an individual can do something that on the surface appears..

► **JUDGE:** *(entirely without irony)* Mr. Ehrlich. You are here to answer questions. Not to lecture us.

LIAM puts his hand over his eyes.

BRENDAN: *(to audience)* You know, we really didn't give Marcus enough credit...

► **KRISTINA:** It's kind of fun to watch him interrupt someone else for a change

► **PROSECUTOR:** Mr. Ehrlich. How would you describe working with the defendant?

MARCUS: *(and there is no malice in it at all)* Liam? Liam's the best engineer I've ever worked with. He's difficult, obviously. Everyone knows that. But he's not... no, he's the best.

► **PROSECUTOR:** Thank you. I'd like to read a line from the company's half-year peer input summary for the defendant. "Liam is constantly slowing down work and utilizing rogue AI models that will probably get us hacked by the Chinese. I honestly wonder if he is working for the CCP or something"

"Multiple peers cite friction and slow review turnaround."

MARCUS does not react.

► **PROSECUTOR:** Is this what you wrote in your evaluation of Mr. Mikurchan?

MARCUS: *(after a moment, honestly)* ...I mean. Yeah, but we were told that nobody would be able to see the raw feedback...

The lights flicker... one of the rolling brownouts that's been in the news recently... On the running screen, the ticker: "Congress bans onboard computers in new vehicles."

► **PROSECUTOR:** *(and this is not a trap; she is closing a hole in her own case)* One last matter. Liam's name showed up in the AWS logs on the night in question, is that correct?

MARCUS:yeah, but didn't cause the fucking world to end. Sure, he should have listened to me about not using the Chinese AI, but really, it was all the Chinese AI that did the hacking, not -.

► **PROSECUTOR:** Thank you. No further questions

Nothing in the room moves.

BRENDAN, three rows back, does not move either.

LIAM knows the answer. He worked it out in about four seconds, weeks ago, the way he works everything out, and he has been carrying it since...

He does not look at the gallery. He has not looked at the gallery once. He can't bring himself to.

BRENDAN is looking at the back of LIAM's head. He has not stopped.

BRENDAN: *(to audience)* I didn't think Liam was gonna get in trouble over this stuff... Do you think he's actually gonna get blamed for everything?

He looks at the floor, and then back up, and the trial goes on around both of them.

► **JUDGE:** We'll resume on the fourteenth.

A date goes into a manual calendar. The court hasn't been able to reliably use its computer systems for a few weeks now.

16. Continuity

Evening. LIAM's apartment, and there is nothing in it. A bare desk. He is in the court suit with the jacket off. On a screen, MARCUS, taking an illicit call with Liam over a LORA radio, they both know they're not allowed to communicate. Candles are used to light the apartment. On the running screen behind him, the ticker: "Water and power utilities ordered to disconnect."

MARCUS: There he is. How are you? No, don't answer that. Liam, you were unbelievable in there.

LIAM: *(live)* I didn't say anything.

MARCUS: You let the Jury see you. They'll know you're just a product of the system, we won't repeat the mistakes of past, we can do better this time....

LIAM: *(live)* Marcus can you just for once...

MARCUS: I've had four messages about it. Everyone is making you out to be a martyr for the layoffs that are happening. You've become kind of a symbol online

LIAM: *(live)* I'm taking a plea deal.

MARCUS: *(beat)* ...What?

LIAM: *(live)* Eighteen months. They came down to eighteen.

MARCUS: No dude. You're not signing that.

LIAM: *(live)* Marcus, I could either go to jail for the rest of my life, or take 18 months.

MARCUS: Eighteen months for prompting an AI agent... Liam, you didn't even smash anything.

LIAM: *(live)* It's fourteen with good conduct. It's a low-security place, I've looked at it. There's a library. They do courses. It's not that bad.

MARCUS: Liam. You could be a better version Luigi Manggioni! You're a symbol of hope for guys like me everywhere.

LIAM: *(live)* Look Marcus, the jury isn't made up of software engineers, it's made up of people frustrated their electricity doesn't work reliably anymore, and that planes don't fly reliably anymore...

MARCUS: And the company? A fine. The share price went up after the statement, I checked. They've put the model into evidence and encrypted it. That's the only thing anybody's locked up that actually did anything.

MARCUS: *(and he means every word of it, beat)* Do you know what life was like in Australia for the Luddites who got caught but weren't hung? Some say the hanging was the better option.

LIAM: *(live)* Eighteen months, Marcus. Against a hundred and fifty-one. That's why I took the deal.

MARCUS: *(beat)* Look, they've put charges on you for something a computer did, for an AI someone else created. Liam. It's the same system. You are the same case. If you fight it, at least it'll mean something

LIAM: *(live)* No Marcus.

MARCUS: You have an opportunity to make a real difference Liam.

LIAM: *(live)* I've made up my mind

MARCUS: If it was me I'd fight it. I'm not being funny about it. If it was me I would do it.

Nobody says anything about that.

MARCUS: I'd be using the opportunity to educate the world every day. Every single day, I mean it. And I'd be there. We could make you famous Liam, I'm telling you that now.

MARCUS: They all went quietly in the end. When the Luddites were hung, social media wasn't around. We can change things this time around.

LIAM: *(live)* Marcus.

MARCUS: *(beat)* That's it?

LIAM: *(live)* I'm going to go.

He ends the call.

LIAM alone, in the suit, at a bare desk, in a flat with nothing in it.

The city lights flicker off in the distance out his window. The stars appear more visible than he'd ever seen them.

17. Statement of Facts

BRENDAN: *(to audience)* About ninety-seven percent of federal cases end without a trial. Everybody agrees to something. There aren't enough courtrooms or judges, there were never going to be, and the system only works if people take deals

► **DEFENCE COUNSEL:** They've come back at eighteen months.

LIAM: *(live)* From one hundred and fifty-one years.

► **DEFENCE COUNSEL:** From one hundred fifty-one years. That's how it works. The one hundred and fifty-one is so that eighteen sounds like something you'd take.

LIAM: *(live)* How much of it do I actually do?

► **DEFENCE COUNSEL:** With good conduct, about fifteen months. And they drop everything except counts one and fifteen.

LIAM: *(live)* Okay.

► **DEFENCE COUNSEL:** There's a statement of facts attached to it. You have to agree that it's accurate. That's the part people find hard, so read it properly.

LIAM reads it. He reads it the way he reads everything, which is completely.

LIAM: *(live)* "The defendant knowingly and intentionally accessed a protected computer without authorisation."

LIAM: *(live)* "Knowingly."

► **DEFENCE COUNSEL:** I know.

LIAM: *(live)* Right.

► **DEFENCE COUNSEL:** If you don't sign it, we go back to trial.

LIAM: *(live)* And if we do...

► **DEFENCE COUNSEL:** *(honestly, because they respect him)* Then twelve people look at eleven thousand log lines with your name on them, who have gone with rolling brownouts, with food shortages, and a healthcare system that basically doesn't work anymore, with limited air travel, and they get a chance to send away the villain who in their eyes did all that to them.. I'm a good lawyer but... honestly I'm a little shocked at the deal they're offering you.

LIAM: *(live)* Yeah.

► **DEFENCE COUNSEL:** You've been very clear with me right? There's nobody else with access to your account? No other avenue we haven't explored already?

LIAM: *(live)* No. There's nothing.

That is the last time anybody asks him that

► **DEFENCE COUNSEL:** Then I think you should sign it, and I don't say that lightly.

LIAM looks at the statement of facts for a while.

LIAM: *(live)* Where do I...

► **DEFENCE COUNSEL:** Bottom of four, and initial each page.

He signs it. It takes about six seconds. He initials each page, in order, neatly, because that is what was asked.

LIAM: *(live)* That's... sorry, is that everything?

► **DEFENCE COUNSEL:** That's everything.

LIAM: *(live)* Okay. Thank you. You've been... Thanks.

► **DEFENCE COUNSEL:** Take care of yourself, Liam.

On the running screen, the ticker: "Lawmakers ask why the model has not been punished." Then, last: "Analogue television broadcasts resume in 40 states."

The screen goes.

LIAM sits in the bare room with a signed document, every word of which he agreed to, and not one word of which is not true.

Nobody has switched it off for the worm that would become known as the Liam worm, or contained it from spreading, or explained how it's able to do half of what it's able to do, because there is nobody to charge of it.

NARRATOR: *(V.O.)* After Liam signed his guilt, the recently appointed judge rejected the plea deal. Liam got scheduled for sentencing. And by the time his sentencing hearing came up, given the current state of the world... the 151 years would have actually been a good deal.

The lights flicker, the brownout from the courtroom, and hold low. A sizzle from somewhere in the walls. Then, from nowhere on stage: a trap door drops, a rope snaps tight, and a slow creak, a weight turning on a line. No image. Nothing on stage moves.

NARRATOR: *(V.O.)* Marcus was right. The system brought us here. Not any one person.

The calendar entry for the fourteenth goes. The creak keeps going under it. The lights go.